

The Evolution of the Demonstrative Pronouns and the Absence of the Definite Article in Old East Slavic

This paper presents a diachronic corpus study of the Old East Slavic demonstrative pronouns with the focus on *the Ostromir* (1056-1057) and *the Arkhangelsk* (1092) *Gospels*. It investigates the diachronic development of the demonstrative pronouns and provides a theoretical account of the absence of a definite article in Old East Slavic. Unlike Old South Slavic in which the definite article emerged from the demonstrative as early as in the 10th-11th centuries, Old East Slavic during the same time period never developed this new functional category. The problem of the diachronic development of the demonstrative pronouns and the emergence of a definite article has been addressed in Old South Slavic (Mladenova 2007, 2009; Dimitrova-Vulchanova and Vulchanov 2010, 2012; Šimko 2020) and Old Church Slavonic (Kuznetsov 2020), but it has not received much attention in Old East Slavic. The present study aims to fill in this gap and suggests that in Old East Slavic the demonstrative did not grammaticalize as the definite article due to the presence of morphological case expressed on nouns. I argue that while in Old South Slavic the loss of morphological case (Mirčev 1978, Mayer 1988, Mladenova 2009 (approximately in the 10th century) crucially and not coincidentally correlates with the rise of the definite article, in Old East Slavic the preservation of morphological case on the noun prevents its emergence.

The analysis of the data from Old East Slavic and Old South Slavic Gospels dating to the 11th century reveals the following observations regarding the development of the definite article. Since Old East Slavic has rich case morphology and as a consequence, free word order, the demonstrative can both precede and follow the noun. However, very often the demonstrative follows the noun rather than precedes it. In Old East Slavic, the distal demonstrative pronoun **tŭ** ('that') follows the noun (Noun-Dem) while in Contemporary Russian it necessarily precedes it (Dem-Noun) (1-2). In contrast, in Old South Slavic the demonstrative **tŭ** ('that') is already attached to the noun as a suffix forming a complex nominal head (3). The suffixation of the demonstrative to the nominal head provides evidence of the emergence of the demonstrative as a suffixed definite article in Old South Slavic. In Contemporary Bulgarian, the definite article appears as a postpositive suffix to the noun (4).

(1) *Old East Slavic*

i padŭ ubo **rabŭ tŭ**

and fell then servant that.Dem.

'And then that servant fell.'

(*The Ostromir Gospel*, Mt 18:26, 75.1)

(2) *Contemporary Russian*

tot rab

that.Dem servant

'that servant'

(3) *Old South Slavic*

padŭ že ubo **rab-o-tŭ**

fell CL then servant-the.Det

'Then the servant fell.'

(*The Assemanius Gospel*, Mt 18:26, 44.2.6)

(4) *Contemporary Bulgarian*

Masa-ta

Table-the.fem.sg.

‘the table’

(Kuteva and Heine 2008:220)

I have created a sub-corpus of demonstrative-modified noun phrases for each of the two gospels using the Old Slavic corpus www.manuscripts.ru. All tokens were annotated and classified according to number (singular-dual-plural), gender (masculine, feminine, and neuter), and case (nominative, accusative, genitive, dative, instrumental, and locative) features. All the tokens were categorized according to the word order of the demonstrative and head noun. The results from the sub-corpus of *the Ostromir Gospel* (1056-1057) show that 59% of the demonstrative-modified noun phrases have the N-Dem word order whereas 41% display the Dem-N word order. Similarly, the results from the sub-corpus of *the Arkhangelsk Gospel* (1092) show that 61.9% of the demonstrative-modified noun phrases have a N-Dem word order while 38.1% are characterized by a Dem-N word order.

I assume that the Old East Slavic noun has a traditional noun-phrase structure, crucially without a DP layer (Corver 1992; Bošković 2005, 2009, 2012; Willim 2000; Despić 2013; Zlatić 2013). The evidence for this structure comes from left-branch extraction and scrambling. I propose that an extended Old East Slavic nominal phase has an agreement phrase (AgrP) generated recursively above the NP, and the Dem is base generated in the Spec of the NP (5). I suggest that the Agr head with case features prevents the Dem from being merged into the D head and being reanalyzed as a determiner (6). This diachronic corpus study has confirmed a close relationship between morphological case and the expression of definiteness. Since Old East Slavic had robust morphological case expressed on nouns, there was no need to encode definiteness in a new functional head D. More importantly, the results of my corpus study lent support to the analysis of demonstrative-modified noun phrases as traditional noun phrases crucially without a DP layer.

(5) [AgrP[AP[Agr Agr']][NP[Dem N'N]]]

(6)

